FARMLIFE

KCFB KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

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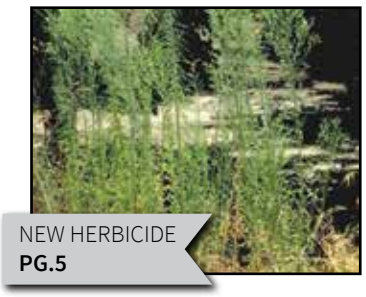
INSIDE



NEW HERBICIDE **PG.5**

APIARY LAWS **PG. 7**

NEW "NEGLECTED FARMLAND" LAWS **PG. 9**

2026: The Quiet Laws Reshaping California Agriculture

California agriculture did not wake up on January 1, 2026, to a single headline-grabbing change.

There was no sweeping ban.

No landmark reform.

No press conference moment that signaled a new era.

Instead, the ground shifted quietly.

A collection of new laws and regulatory adjustments taking effect in early 2026 is beginning to reshape how agriculture operates across California. None of these changes, on their own, will make or break a farming operation. Taken together, they redraw the margins financially, operationally, and politically.

This is governance by accumulation. And it matters.

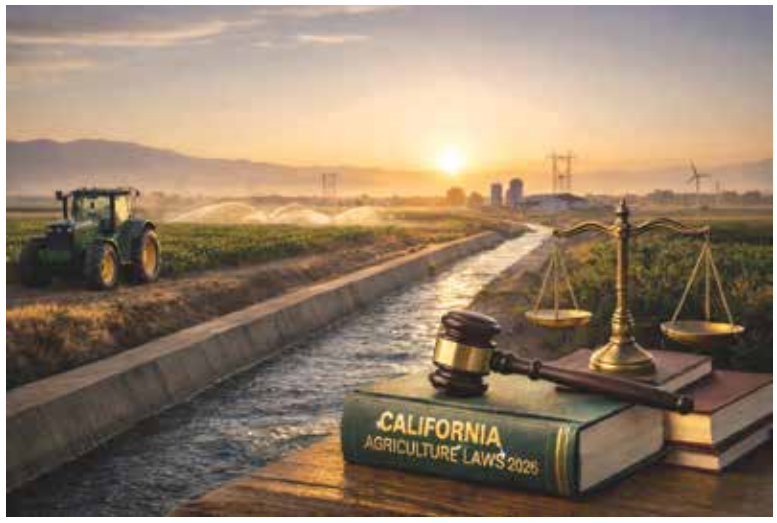
Incremental change is often more durable than sweeping reform. It avoids backlash, minimizes attention, and embeds itself slowly into daily decision-making. Over time, those changes alter behavior just as effectively as a single dramatic policy shift. The difference is that they often do so without the clarity or accountability of a defining moment.

For farmers and ranchers already navigating SGMA implementation, labor shortages, market volatility, and rising compliance costs, 2026 adds another layer to that reality. Not as a shock, but as pressure.

Not louder.

Not faster.

But more precise.



LABOR: THE COST FLOOR CONTINUES TO RISE

As expected, California's statewide minimum wage increased again on January 1, reaching $16.90 per hour.

For agriculture, this increase is no longer a surprise. It is a fixed condition of operating in the state. Each adjustment compounds across base wages, overtime exposure, piece-rate calculations, payroll taxes, workers' compensation premiums, and administrative burden. Even operations that have already moved well above minimum wage feel the effect as pay scales compress and upward pressure moves through entire crews.

The impact is not evenly distributed. Labor-intensive crops,

New Law continued on page 14

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The State Is Back at the Table; Local Work Moves Forward

by Julie Martella

January brought a clear shift across the Tulare Lake Subbasin: communication with the State Water Resources Control Board has resumed, and local GSAs are continuing to advance the policies and programs that will shape the year ahead.

This month's updates included allocation decisions, reporting reminders, well mitigation refinements, and early steps to prepare for the next phase of SGMA implementation.

What Changed Across the Subbasin This Month

State staff have resumed conversations with the Tulare Lake Subbasin GSAs after more than a year of limited coordination during litigation and injunction proceedings. Several GSAs met with State staff, and another follow-up meeting is expected later this month.

Although the State did not commit to specific timelines for hearings or revised plan review, the message to local agencies was clear: reporting expectations remain in effect, fees will be collected, and the subbasin will need to stay organized, proactive, and aligned, where possible, to avoid an interim plan.

Your Postcard From the State: Read It and Save It

Many landowners in the Tulare Lake Subbasin have recently received a postcard from the State Water Resources Control Board outlining groundwater extraction reporting requirements. The postcard lists a reporting period of **July 15, 2024 through September 30, 2025,** with a stated reporting deadline of **May 1, 2026**.

At the same time, the State's reporting requirements may change as ongoing legal and administrative actions continue.

For now, landowners should not ignore the postcard. Save it, share it with whoever manages your farm records, and be aware of the information it contains. Staying informed and keeping basic records organized helps ensure you are prepared for future guidance as it becomes available.

El Rico: Annual Reporting Is the Immediate Priority

El Rico held a brief meeting this month with no public comments and no agenda changes. The minutes were approved,

SGMA continued on pg 11

KCFB
KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

Purpose
Protect, preserve and enhance agriculture in Kings County

Vision
Ensure that every farmer has the right to farm and protect their heritage

Values
Our Members | Proactive Representative
Reliable | Trusted Resource

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Brian Potter
Kevin Robertson
Kevin Ruble
Daniel Soares
Helen Sullivan
Frank Zonneveld

Executive Director
Dusty Ference
dusty.ference@kcfb.org

Farm Life Advertising
kcfb@kcfb.org

Farm Life Designer
Beth Greene

CFBF District Representative
John Moore III

Contact
870 Greenfield Ave., Hanford, CA 93230
Phone: (559) 584-3557
www.kcfb.org

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KCFB Executive Director's Report

Dusty Ference

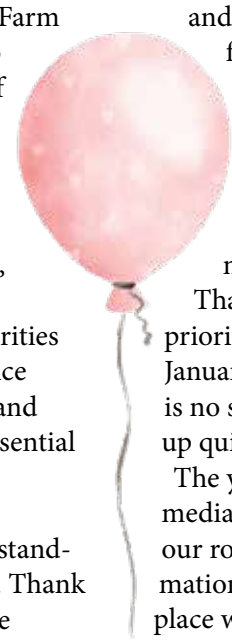
January has looked a little different than usual for me and for the Farm Bureau office, and I wanted to take a moment to share a brief update with our membership.

Earlier this month, my wife and I welcomed our second daughter into the world. As many families know firsthand, that kind of moment requires time, focus, and a shift in priorities at home. As a result, I have been largely out of the office throughout January. While I have remained engaged and available as needed, this month has been limited to essential work only.

First and foremost, I want to say thank you.

Thank you to our Board of Directors for their understanding, flexibility, and steady leadership during this time. Thank you to our staff for keeping the day-to-day work of the organization moving forward smoothly. And thank you to the many members who reached out with kind notes, messages, and well-wishes. Those gestures did not go unnoticed, and they were sincerely appreciated.

One of the strengths of the Kings County Farm Bureau is that it is bigger than any one person. The work continues because it is grounded in clear roles, shared responsibility, and a strong sense of purpose. Over the course of January, that structure mattered. The office remained responsive, programs stayed on track, and the organization continued to represent agriculture in Kings County as issues evolved.



This short period also provided an opportunity to step back and reflect. That can be difficult to do in the middle of a full calendar. It reinforced the importance of delegation, documentation, and continuity of operations. It also highlighted how much institutional knowledge and commitment exists within our staff and leadership.

As I transition back into a more regular schedule, my focus is on re engaging fully with the work ahead. That includes reconnecting with board and committee priorities, reviewing developments that occurred during January, and advancing projects already underway. There is no shortage of work in front of us, and the pace will pick up quickly.

The year ahead will require steady attention to both immediate challenges and longer term planning. As always, our role as a Farm Bureau is to provide reliable information, advocate for practical solutions, and serve as a place where farmers, ranchers, and rural residents can stay informed and connected. That mission does not pause, even when individual schedules change.

I am grateful for the patience and professionalism shown during this important personal chapter. I am equally grateful for the opportunity to lead an organization that values both commitment to the work and respect for family. Those two things are not in conflict. In many cases, they are the reason the work matters in the first place.

Thank you for your continued trust and support. I look forward to being fully back at it and to the conversations and challenges ahead.

SGMA Litigation Update: Court Orders Further Review Before Ruling

A recent court hearing in the ongoing Sustainable Groundwater Management Act litigation provided important procedural clarity, even though no formal ruling was issued. Although the judge did not resolve the disputed issues at the hearing, her comments and instructions indicate that key legal questions remain unresolved and will be addressed through additional briefing.

Representatives and legal counsel attended the hearing on behalf of Kings County Farm Bureau. Based on counsel's assessment, the hearing preserved existing legal arguments and prevented the State Water Resources Control Board from accelerating the case despite unresolved issues.

Preliminary Injunction Remains Unresolved

A central issue at the hearing was the State's assertion that a previously issued preliminary injunction had been nullified, allowing the State to resume fee collection related to probation. During the hearing, the Judge verbally disagreed with the State's characterization of the injunction.

That disagreement did not result in an immediate ruling. Instead, the Judge indicated she wants to review additional briefing and supporting documents before reaching a decision. The Court did not declare the injunction invalid, nor did it affirm the State's authority to collect fees. The issue remains under judicial review.

Court Declines to Fast-Track the Case

The most consequential outcome of the hearing was procedural.

The State pushed for a faster path and sought to move directly to the merits of the case. Legal counsel objected, noting that additional causes of action remain unresolved and that the relevant administrative records must be reviewed before any merits determination can occur.

The Judge agreed. She directed the parties to submit opening briefs by February 13 and scheduled a hearing on those briefs for March 12.

This decision confirms the Court's intent to fully examine unresolved legal and procedural issues before allowing the case to proceed. It also prevents the State from bypassing outstanding claims or compressing the timeline in ways that could affect landowners' rights.

Back Fees and Reporting Requirements Still Open

Questions surrounding back fees and reporting

SGMA Litigation continued on page 14

KCFB

KINGS edc

ECONOMIC IMPACT REPORT 2024

INTRODUCTION

Kings County agriculture remains a vital part of the local economy, fueling growth, creating jobs, and supporting community investment. This report emphasizes agriculture's contribution to the county's $7.7 billion GDP, its above-average wages, and its ripple effect across various industries. From supporting over 8,000 jobs to generating millions in property taxes, agriculture continues to anchor Kings County's economic stability and future growth.

AVERAGE ANNUAL WAGES FOR AG

$65,644[1]

AVERAGE ANNUAL ALL INDUSTRIES

$58,005[1]

AGRICULTURE WAGES ARE

13.2%

Higher than the average in Kings County

AG PAYS APPROXIMATELY $44.3 MILLION IN PROPERTY TAXES EACH YEAR[2]

- **22.65%** to the County, Fire Department, & Libraries
- **13.94%** to Rural Development Agency
- **6.19%** to the Cities
- **6.09%** to Special Districts

MULTIPLIER FOR EMPLOYMENT

1.47[1]

Indirect and Induced Job Creation

For every job in agriculture, about one and a half more jobs are created in other parts of the economy.

JOBS TOTAL IN AG

8,139[1]

JOB TOTAL ALL INDUSTRIES 53,281[1]

AG makes up aproximately **15%**

1 Source: JobsEQ®, http://www.chmuraecon.com/jobseq
2 Kings County Assessor's Office
Annual Wages, 2024 Q4. Employment 2024 Q4. Economic Impact-Multiplier 2024 Q4; GDP 2023.

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Content for this month's "Ag News in Brief," provided by the California Farm Bureau Federation

AG NEWS IN BRIEF

CDFA Lifts Statewide Ban on California Poultry and Dairy Cattle Exhibitions at Fairs and Shows

The California Department of Food and Agriculture has lifted its statewide ban on poultry and dairy cattle exhibitions at fairs and shows, ending a restriction that had broad ripple effects across youth programs, breeders, and fair operations throughout the state.

The ban was initially put in place as a precautionary measure amid heightened concerns about avian influenza and other transmissible livestock diseases. During that period, animal movement was tightly restricted, forcing many county fairs and exhibition programs to cancel livestock components or shift to static displays. For youth exhibitors, the disruption went beyond missed events, affecting project completion, eligibility requirements, and long-standing educational pathways.

CDFA indicated that the decision to lift the ban reflects improved disease conditions and sustained compliance with enhanced biosecurity measures. Producers, veterinarians, and fair operators implemented stricter sanitation protocols, health screening requirements, controlled animal transport, and herd immunity strategies. State officials specifically cited producers' cooperation as a key factor in allowing exhibitions to resume.

For rural communities, livestock exhibitions remain a cornerstone of county fairs, serving economic, educational, and outreach roles. The return of live animal exhibitions restores a direct connection between the public and production agriculture at a time when that visibility continues to matter.

CDFA emphasized that biosecurity expectations remain elevated. Organizers and exhibitors should expect continued scrutiny, documentation requirements, and the possibility of future restrictions if disease conditions change.

FCC Announces Ban on All Foreign-Made Drones

The Federal Communications Commission announced a ban on authorizing new foreign-made drones and drone components for use in the United States, citing national security concerns tied to data transmission, communications infrastructure, and supply chain vulnerabilities.

Drones already in use and models previously approved remain legal to operate. However, new approvals for certain foreign-manufactured unmanned aircraft systems will no longer be issued. While the policy is framed around national security, the implications for agriculture are practical and immediate.

Unmanned aircraft systems are now common tools on California farms and ranches, particularly in specialty crop production and large acreage operations. Producers rely on drones for crop scouting, irrigation evaluation, plant health monitoring, and mapping. In many cases, drones have reduced labor needs and improved response time when conditions change quickly.

The ban raises questions about future equipment availability, replacement parts, service support, and pricing. Reduced competition in the drone market could increase costs or limit access to specialized platforms. At the same time, the decision may accelerate domestic manufacturing and investment in U.S.-based drone technology.

Producers who rely heavily on drones may want to inventory current equipment, assess parts availability, and track how implementation details unfold over the next year.

CDFW to Conduct Helicopter Capture and Collaring Efforts for Deer, Elk and Gray Wolves in Northern California

The California Department of Fish and Wildlife will conduct helicopter capture and GPS collaring operations for deer, elk, and gray wolves across several Northern California counties during January.

The effort is part of CDFW's ongoing wildlife research and monitoring program, which tracks movement patterns, habitat use, and population dynamics. Wolf collaring will focus on Siskiyou, Lassen, and Tehama counties, with potential expansion depending on conditions and research needs.

For livestock producers, wolf monitoring remains a closely watched issue. GPS collar data is often used to inform depredation response protocols, compensation claims, and longer term management discussions. While the collaring effort does not change regulations on its own, the data collected can influence agency priorities and future policy decisions.

CDFW stated that helicopter operations are conducted by trained professionals following established animal welfare standards. Coordination with local authorities and public safety planning are also part of the process. Producers in affected areas may see low-flying aircraft during operations and are encouraged to monitor local notices for timing and location details.

CDFA Extends Organic Avian Flu Biosecurity Measures

CDFA has extended biosecurity measures specific to organic poultry operations as part of its continued response to avian influenza risks.

Organic producers face unique challenges during avian influenza outbreaks due to requirements for outdoor access and pasture-based management. These requirements can conflict with disease prevention practices designed to limit exposure to wild birds and other vectors. CDFA has worked with certifiers, veterinarians, and industry representatives to tailor expectations while maintaining compliance with organic certification standards.

Extended measures include continued monitoring, reporting requirements, and movement controls. CDFA characterized the extension as precautionary and indicated that it will be reevaluated as surveillance data and risk assessments evolve.

For organic operations, consistency remains the key takeaway. Clear records, controlled access points, and practical risk reduction measures are likely to matter as much as formal rule language as enforcement and oversight continue.

CDFA Awards Nearly $27 Million Through Dairy Plus Program

CDFA has awarded nearly $27 million in grant funding through its Dairy Plus Program to support greenhouse gas mitigation and water quality improvement projects across California's dairy sector.

The program builds on earlier state investments focused on methane reduction, manure management improvements, and long-term environmental performance. Funded projects include infrastructure upgrades, technology adoption, and operational improvements designed to deliver measurable environmental benefits.

For dairy producers, the program offers an opportunity to offset capital costs while modernizing facilities and improving regulatory compliance. State officials emphasize that the intent is to keep dairies viable while advancing California's environmental goals.

Demand for the program remains strong. Producers interested in future funding rounds should pay close attention to scoring criteria, matching requirements, and documentation expectations, as competition for funding continues to be high.

President Signs Dairy Bill

President Donald Trump signed the Whole Milk for Healthy Kids Act, allowing schools participating in the National School Lunch Program to offer whole milk once again.

Supporters argue that whole milk provides essential nutrients and that expanded options may increase student participation in school meal programs. The legislation aligns with updated dietary guidance that recognizes the role of healthy fats and dairy in balanced diets, particularly for children.

The bill passed both chambers of Congress with bipartisan support and has been backed by dairy industry groups that have long advocated for greater flexibility in school nutrition standards. For pro-

AG NEWS continued on page 5

New Herbicide Shows Promise for Controlling Tough Weeds in Almond Orchards

Mandeep Riar

By Mandeep Riar, Restoration Ecology and Weed Science Advisor, UCCE Kern, Tulare, Kings
Jorge Angeles, Weed management Advisor, UCCE Tulare, Kings, Fresno

Keeping orchards clean has become more challenging for California almond growers in recent years, especially as tough weeds like horseweed and hairy fleabane continue to spread. A recent field study done by the University of California Cooperative Extension advisors offers some encouraging results for growers looking for new and reliable weed control options.

We evaluated the performance of a newer herbicide, florpyrauxifen-benzyl, sold under the trade name Hulk® for controlling difficult weeds in almond orchards. Hulk® belongs to a group of herbicides known as synthetic auxins, which work by disrupting normal plant growth. Susceptible weeds show abnormal growth, epinasty, ruptured stems, leaf malformations and eventually die overtime. One key advantage of Hulk® is that it is non-volatile and does not readily move off target. It can also be applied at any time of the year, giving growers more flexibility compared to some older products that have seasonal or regional restrictions.

Mature horseweed plant. Credit: Jack Kelly Clark, UC IPM

The study focused on two of the most troublesome weeds in almond orchards: horseweed and hairy fleabane. The trial was conducted during May-August 2025 at the UC Shafter Research Farm in an almond orchard where horseweed and hairy fleabane were already well established, averaging about 10 to 11 inches tall. The herbicide treatments were applied during the last week of May and weed control observations were recorded for up to 8 weeks after treatment. The treatments included Hulk at 16 oz/acre and 21 oz/acre rates. Tank-mix combinations of Hulk + Rely 280 (glufosinate), Hulk + Roundup PM3 (glyphosate), Rely 280 + Roundup PM3, and Treevix + Roundup PM3 were included in the study. All treatments that included Hulk® provided excellent control of horseweed, with complete control observed by eight weeks after treatment. Hairy fleabane proved slightly more difficult to manage, but all Hulk® treatments still achieved at least 90% control. The combination of Hulk® plus glufosinate consistently provided the strongest and fastest results. In some areas where Hulk® was used alone, hairy fleabane plants stayed green longer. However, these plants showed clear

Herbicide continued on page 11

2026–27 California Governor's Budget

Governor Gavin Newsom released his proposed 2026–27 State Budget in January, outlining a roughly $349 billion spending plan as he enters the final year of his administration. While the proposal avoids major new agricultural initiatives, it maintains funding for several programs that directly affect farmers, ranchers, and rural communities.

Water and Infrastructure

The budget continues to rely heavily on bond funding, including Proposition 4 resources, for water-related investments. Funding priorities include flood protection projects, drinking water and wastewater upgrades in disadvantaged communities, and repairs to state conveyance infrastructure. While these investments support long-term water resilience, they remain largely one-time allocations rather than ongoing program funding.

Wildfire and Forestry

Wildfire response remains a major focus. The budget increases funding for fire suppression and emergency response, while funding for local wildfire resilience and prevention programs declines compared to prior years. Forestry staffing and program levels remain largely unchanged, signaling a continued emphasis on response rather than expanded prevention efforts.

Pesticide Regulation and Farm Safety

The Department of Pesticide Regulation's core funding remains stable. The proposal includes limited special-fund increases to support pesticide notification systems and fumigant exposure monitoring, with no major expansion of regulatory programs or enforcement activity proposed at this stage.

CA Budget continued on page 13

AG NEWS continued from page 4

ducers, the market impact is expected to be gradual rather than immediate, but the policy shift is directionally positive.

Federal nutrition policy influences long-term demand signals. Restoring whole milk options places dairy more squarely back into national nutrition programs and reinforces its role in institutional food markets.

USDA Announces New 2026 Priorities for Research and Development

The United States Department of Agriculture has announced its research and development priorities for 2026, outlining a framework focused on climate resilience, agricultural innovation, and rural economic development.

Priority areas include climate-smart agriculture, water efficiency, soil health, animal disease prevention, and emerging technologies. USDA also emphasized research that supports producer profitability, supply chain resilience, and food system security.

For producers and ag organizations, the value of this announcement lies in what it signals about future funding. Universities and industry partners often align grant proposals with these priorities, which can later translate into on-farm trials, technical assistance programs, and applied research opportunities.

Producers engaged with commodity groups or research institutions may see increased opportunities tied to these focus areas in the coming year.

House and Senate Pass Various Funding Packages Ahead of Jan. 30 Deadline

The House and Senate are advancing multiple spending packages in an effort to avoid a Jan. 30 deadline to keep the federal government funded. Measures in both chambers have passed with supermajorities, reflecting a more bipartisan approach than the extended shutdown that began last fall.

Several hurdles remain. Funding for the U.S. Department of Homeland Security has not yet been resolved, and recent developments involving U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement have added uncertainty to negotiations. Planned off weeks for both chambers could also affect the timing of final votes.

For agriculture, the funding outcome matters. USDA programs, conservation initiatives, loan processing, research activities, and technical assistance all depend on uninterrupted federal operations. While lawmakers have expressed optimism that a shutdown can be avoided, producers and ag organizations are watching closely as the deadline approaches.

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SGMA DEFENSE FUND
KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

Join the Fight!

THIS EFFORT HAS SAVED GROWERS IN THE TULARE LAKE SUBBASIN $40-$60/ACRE AND $300/WELL SINCE KCFB WAS ISSUED A PRELIMINARY INJUNCTION.

CONTRIBUTE $15/ACRE TO THE SGMA DEFENSE FUND

Ag Commissioner's Compliance Report

Jimmy Hook, Agricultural Commissioner/Sealer

New Apiary Law Changes in California

Beginning January 1, 2026, California has introduced significant updates to its apiary regulations, and Kings County is ready to put these changes into action. Under new agreements with the California Department of Food and Agriculture (CDFA), County Agricultural Commissioners (CACs) will take on expanded responsibilities for registering and inspecting apiaries to ensure compliance and protect pollinator health.

What's Changing?

Every beekeeper, broker, or individual who owns or manages an apiary in California must register their colonies and locations. Registration is not optional—it's a legal requirement designed to improve oversight and safeguard the state's beekeeping industry. These registrations will be managed through the BeeWhere platform, which helps track hive locations and promotes transparency across agricultural operations.

Kings County's Agricultural Commissioner will focus on assisting beekeepers with registration, verifying compliance, and conducting outreach to ensure that all apiary operators understand their obligations under the updated law. This includes sending reminders, providing technical support for BeeWhere, and monitoring registrations throughout the county.

Expanded Inspection Program

Alongside registration, inspections will play a critical role in enforcing the new standards. Trained apiary inspectors will conduct targeted inspections based on complaints, new hive locations reported in BeeWhere, or observations during routine agricultural work. These inspections will address key areas of the California Food & Agriculture Code, including:

- **Apiary Markings Compliance** (FAC §29046)
- **Importation Certification Enforcement** (FAC §29120–29128)
- **Pest Abatement and Administrative Actions** (FAC §29200–29213)

Examples of inspection activities include investigating misplaced hives, enforcing quarantines, and controlling serious diseases such as American Foulbrood. Inspectors will also oversee the proper disposal of contaminated hives and equipment to prevent the spread of pests and pathogens.

Why This Work Matters

Honeybees are the backbone of California agriculture, pollinating crops that feed millions of people. Without healthy bee populations, the state's ability to produce almonds, fruits, vegetables, and other essential crops would be severely compromised. Protecting bees is not just an agricultural issue—it's an economic and environmental priority.

Accurate hive registration and location data also play a critical role in pesticide safety. Many pesticides used in crop production can be harmful to bees if applied near active hives. By using the BeeWhere system, pesticide applicators can see where hives are located and adjust their practices to avoid exposure. This collaboration between beekeepers, growers, and regulators helps prevent accidental hive losses and ensures that pollination services remain strong for California's diverse agricultural landscape.

Kings County contains over 206,000 colonies of bees and nearly 35,000 acres of almonds that rely on them for pollination. By enforcing registration and inspection requirements, Kings County helps prevent the spread of pests and diseases that can devastate colonies. These efforts also reduce conflicts between beekeepers and growers by improving hive placement transparency. Ultimately, this program strengthens pollinator health, supports sustainable farming, and ensures that California remains a leader in agricultural production.

For more information or to register your apiary, visit the BeeWhere platform at https://beewhere.calagpermits.org . You can also contact the Kings County Agricultural Commissioner's office at agstaff@co.kings.ca.us or call (559) 852-2830.

From Waste to Input

How California's 2026 Compost and Organics Laws Are Rewiring On-Farm Practices

For years, California's organic waste policies have lived in two worlds.

In one, cities, landfills, and recycling programs grapple with diversion targets, methane reduction, and climate goals. In the other, farmers contend with nutrients, soil structure, logistics, water quality rules, and cost.

In 2026, those two worlds are being forced closer together.

A set of new laws and regulatory changes taking effect this year expands on-farm composting options, increases allowable compost application thresholds, and removes regulatory barriers that have historically made organic material more trouble than it was worth for producers.

The message from the state is increasingly clear: farmland is no longer just food-producing land; it's also part of California's waste management and climate strategy.

WHAT CHANGED IN 2026

New laws now expand legal pathways for on-farm composting, increase allowable application thresholds for agricultural compost, and reduce regulatory friction that previously discouraged on-farm composting operations.

This is not deregulation. It's re-engineering.

WHY THE STATE IS PUSHING THIS

California faces mandatory organic waste diversion targets, landfill methane-reduction goals, climate-emissions mandates, and limited landfill capacity.

Agricultural land offers something urban infrastructure can't: scale.

Farms and ranches can absorb, process, and apply organic material in volumes that no municipal system can handle efficiently.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR GROWERS

For some producers, these changes lower compliance

Waste/Input continued on page 11

Put earnings back in your pocket with competitive borrowing rates and an annual cash dividend through our Patronage Program.

In 2025, AgWest paid the equivalent of 1.25% of eligible average daily loan balances back to our customer-owners.

AgWestFC.com

AgWest FARM CREDIT

Equal Housing Lender
This institution is an equal opportunity provider and employer.

When Fallow Land Becomes a Liability

What California's New "Neglected Farmland" Law Means for Growers and Landowners in 2026

For decades, leaving ground idle was often a neutral act in California agriculture. Markets shifted. Water disappeared. Ownership changed. Fields sat.

In 2026, that calculation changes.

A new state law now gives county agricultural commissioners explicit authority to intervene when abandoned or neglected farmland becomes a pest, weed, or disease nuisance. While the statute doesn't require anyone to plant crops, it redefines when "doing nothing" becomes a regulatory problem.

For producers navigating SGMA-driven fallowing, land transitions, or inherited property, this law quietly raises the stakes.

WHAT THE LAW ACTUALLY DOES

The law authorizes county agricultural commissioners to act when unmanaged land creates conditions that harbor pests, spread weeds, or threaten neighboring agricultural operations.

When that threshold is reached, counties may issue a formal notice, require corrective action, and impose civil penalties if conditions persist.

The focus is on nuisance, not land use.

WHY THIS MATTERS NOW

This authority arrives at a moment when large acreage is being fallowed due to SGMA, ownership is increasingly absentee, and unmanaged land is drawing complaints.

Fallow land is no longer invisible.

WHAT COUNTS AS NEGLECT

Neglect is not defined as simply not farming. Counties will look for uncontrolled weeds, pest infestations, unmanaged crops, or impacts on neighbors.

Two fallowed fields may be treated very differently depending on management.

COUNTY DISCRETION IS THE REAL VARIABLE

Enforcement will vary widely by county and often be complaint-driven. Relationships, staffing, and local pressure will matter.

SGMA AND FALLOWED LAND

SGMA does not exempt land from nuisance expectations. A field fallowed for water-related reasons may still require management.

WHAT LANDOWNERS SHOULD DO

Maintain weed and pest control, document actions, respond promptly to notices, and communicate early with county officials.

BOTTOM LINE

Leaving land idle is no longer passive. In 2026, stewardship expectations apply even when farming is impractical.

EXCELSIOR/KINGS RIVER
Resource Conservation District

SUPPORTING FARMERS IN PORTIONS OF **FRESNO, KINGS, AND TULARE COUNTIES**

WELLUP Program

EKRCD's WELLUP program provides farmers in its region and surrounding areas with the technical support to evaluate their farm's water supply health and plan for drought impacts and water shortages.

Program Benefits

Pump Efficiency Testing

- FREE pump tests for eligible producers.
- Up to 6 tests per producer (Non-SDFR).
- Up to 10 tests per producer (SDFR*).
- Available regardless of acreage or farm size.

Program Eligibility

To qualify for WELLUP submit an intake form.

Who can apply?

Farmers and producers in Fresno, Kings, and Tulare Counties.

Special incentives are available for Socially Disadvantaged Farmers & Ranchers (SDFR).

ekrcd.org **Call us at: 559.309.4030**

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Groundwater Allocations continued from page 1

and the meeting moved into closed session.

The key takeaway for stakeholders was timing and readiness. El Rico emphasized that annual reporting is approaching and that early data input matters. The Data Management System (DMS) is tied to ILRP reporting processes, and El Rico's internal timeline may require landowners to submit data before ILRP deadlines.

The annual report is due April 1, and the GSA noted that the consultant will need time to compile the final report after the landowner data has been entered.

South Fork Kings: The Allocation Policy Is Adopted and Now in Effect

Allocation Set at 0.86 AF per Acre

South Fork Kings approved its revised Groundwater Allocation Policy, which has been adopted as the current framework. The allocation methodology was approved at 0.86 acre-feet per acre, with the total basin allocation unchanged. South Fork Kings described the approach as a hybrid model, using historical pumping totals in areas with limited pumping and distributing the remaining allocation evenly across other areas.

2026 Is a Dashboard Year Only

The Board emphasized that Water Year 2026 (October 1, 2025, through September 30, 2026) will be a dashboard-only year. During this year, growers will be able to see how pumping is tracked, and there will be no pumping fees or penalties. The purpose is transparency and system testing.

Enforcement Begins October 1, 2026

Starting October 1, 2026, pumping fees and penalties will begin, and allocation limits will be enforced.

Well Mitigation Rules Continue to Tighten

South Fork Kings also discussed changes to the Well Mitigation Program intended to tighten eligibility requirements and protect the program's long-term credibility. Proposed revisions included well age limits, ownership requirements, habitable dwelling standards, a limit of one claim per APN, documentation requirements tied to water quality impacts, and funding caps with payback provisions if a property is sold.

South Fork Kings reported that well registration remains at approximately 67 percent, with no new wells registered.

Mid-Kings River: Stakeholder Committee Moved Key Items Forward for Board Action

The Mid-Kings River Stakeholders' Advisory Committee met several times during the holiday season to advance key programs, finalize budget recommendations, and present several updates for formal Board consideration. These items are not final until the Mid-Kings River GSA Board reviews and approves them at a future meeting.

RFQ Recommendations

The committee recommended approval of three of the four proposals. For the fourth program, the committee plans to hear presentations from the remaining candidates on how they would run the program before making a final recommendation. This fourth item focuses on the administration and delivery of the well registration program.

Budget Recommendation Finalized

After extensive discussion and review, the committee confirmed its final budget recommendation. The discussion focused on making the budget as efficient as possible while still supporting SGMA implementation, outreach needs, and program administration.

Well Mitigation Policy Revisions Advanced

The committee also revised the Well Mitigation Policy and advanced the updated draft for Board consideration. Revisions included eligibility and program safeguards, such as considerations related to well age, habitable dwellings, and other qualifying criteria intended to keep the program consistent, fair, and workable.

Tri-County: Coordination Continues, and Compliance Tools Are Strengthening

Tri-County reported that subbasin-wide agreement on sustainable yield distribution is still being negotiated. Different methodologies remain in use across GSAs, and Tri-County indicated it will continue operating under its adopted framework while coordination discussions continue.

Tri-County also reported ongoing work on compliance and fee collection, noting that it is strengthening its tools to address long-term noncompliance. In Tule, the Board has begun taking clearer steps to address delinquent fees, signaling that enforcement expectations are tightening across the region.

Southwest Kings: No Meeting This Month

Southwest Kings did not hold a meeting this month.

What You Can Do:

A lot is moving at once right now. The best thing the agricultural community can do is stay organized, stay informed, and take small steps early so nothing becomes urgent at the last minute.

1. Organize your reporting information now. Even a simple folder or checklist will make the May deadline easier.
2. Save the postcard from the State and share it with whoever handles your farm records. It includes the reporting period and deadline in writing.
3. Keep basic tracking notes on pumping and water sources. Clear records help prevent confusion later.
4. If you pump larger volumes, double-check meter requirements and keep your readings accessible.
5. Stay engaged with your local GSA updates. Policies on allocation, well mitigation, and outreach are continuing to develop.
6. If a neighbor is confused about timelines, share accurate information. A quick conversation now can prevent stress later.
7. Keep up to date with the latest happenings in your GSA, whether by signing up for email notifications via their website or through social media.

These are manageable steps that go a long way toward keeping the community steady and prepared as this next phase unfolds.

Stay Steady. Stay Informed. Stay Ready.

January's meetings made one thing clear: the Tulare Lake Subbasin is entering a more active SGMA season. Some policies are now adopted, others are advancing through committees toward Board action, and several programs are being refined to work fairly and efficiently on the ground.

For stakeholders, the most important takeaway is simple: pay attention to the deadlines that have been put in writing, watch for local updates, and take a few small steps early so you are not scrambling later.

This is how we stay steady as a community: informed, practical, and prepared.

Herbicide continued from page 5

injury symptoms and did not regrow. Although the Roundup PM3 + Rely 280 treatment at high rates fully controlled both weed species, it is possible to achieve comparable results with standalone Hulk or with tank-mix combinations with Roundup PM3 or Rely 280 at lower rates.

Overall, the study shows that Hulk® is a valuable new option for almond growers dealing with herbicide-resistant weeds. It can be used alone or in tank mixes to improve control, reduce reliance on older chemistries, and support resistance management strategies. With its flexible application timing and strong performance on difficult weeds, florpyrauxifen-benzyl adds an important tool to the almond weed management toolbox. For specific recommendations, check with your local UC Cooperative Extension advisor or Mandeep Riar at mriar@ucanr.edu. Always follow the product label and state regulations when using herbicides. Product names are mentioned for information and do not represent endorsement.

Waste/Input continued from page 7

barriers and expand options. For others, they introduce new material flows, business solicitations, and regulatory exposure.

On-farm composting is not just agronomy; it is logistics and liability.

ON-FARM COMPOSTING: OPPORTUNITY AND RISK

Benefits include nutrient cycling, soil improvement, and reduced disposal costs. Risks include air and water compliance, odor complaints, neighbor conflicts, and permit complexity.

THE COMPLIANCE WEB REMAINS

Even with expanded authority, composting intersects with air districts, water boards, CDFA, counties, and CalRecycle.

THE DIRECTION OF TRAVEL

California is deploying agriculture as environmental infrastructure.

BOTTOM LINE

The 2026 compost and organics changes are not just about soil health. They are about integrating agriculture into the state's environmental compliance framework.

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Steven E. Alfieris • Ella R. Floresca
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Kings County Rural Crime Report

By Kings County Sheriff's Office – Rural Crimes Unit

During January, the Kings County Sheriff's Office received multiple reports of thefts affecting the local agricultural community. These incidents remain under active investigation by the Sheriff's Office Rural Crimes Unit.

Agricultural Chemical Thefts Under Investigation

The first reported theft occurred near Clinton Avenue and 8th Avenue, where approximately 400 gallons of IVC 440 Supreme Spray Oil were stolen. The estimated value of the product is $2,500.

A second, unrelated chemical theft was reported near 14th Avenue and Fargo Avenue, involving the loss of Treevix and Alion herbicides valued at approximately $20,000.

Fuel and Equipment Trailers Stolen

A fuel trap wagon was stolen from a field near 10th Avenue and Houston Avenue in Hanford. The trailer is yellow, approximately 8 feet long by 5 feet wide, with a single axle and a 600-gallon diesel fuel tank. "Alcala Farms" is painted in blue lettering on both sides.

In a separate incident, a shade trailer was stolen from 7½ Avenue and Whitley Avenue in Corcoran. The trailer is orange and gray and approximately 12 feet long.

Irrigation Well Wire Theft Causes Significant Damage

Two irrigation wells and their electrical panels were damaged near 4th Avenue and Denver Avenue. Copper and aluminum wiring were stolen, with replacement costs estimated at $20,000.

Suspects Arrested in Recycling Wire Theft Case

Investigators identified two suspects from Coalinga who recycled nearly 1,400 pounds of stolen communication wire for approximately $3,200. Both were arrested following a traffic stop.

Report Suspicious Activity

Anyone with information is encouraged to contact the Kings County Sheriff's Office Rural Crimes Unit.

CA Budget continued from page 5

Nutrition and Food Programs

Universal school meals continue statewide. While some state funding declines due to technical adjustments, the budget includes $100 million in one-time funding for school kitchen infrastructure. These upgrades are intended to support scratch cooking and expanded use of locally sourced food, potentially creating new market opportunities for California producers. The budget also reflects increased state costs associated with changes to federal nutrition programs.

What Is Not Included

The proposal does not include significant new funding for agricultural climate programs, land conservation initiatives, or expanded on-farm assistance. Many existing programs are maintained at current levels but are not expanded.

Why It Matters

For agriculture, the 2026–27 budget is largely a status quo proposal. It preserves key infrastructure investments and regulatory operations but relies heavily on bonds and special funds rather than long-term general fund commitments. Legislative negotiations in the coming months will determine whether these priorities shift and whether additional agriculture-focused funding is added before the budget is finalized.

New Law continued from page 1

hand-harvest operations, and producers competing in national or global markets face a different reality than vertically integrated or highly mechanized systems. For some, labor is no longer a variable cost. It is the dominant one.

The message from Sacramento has been consistent for years. Labor will not get cheaper, and relief is not coming from state policy.

As a result, many operations are no longer asking how to absorb higher wages year to year. They are asking more fundamental questions. Which crops still pencil out? Which practices are still viable? Which operations remain sustainable under California's cost structure?

Those decisions ripple outward, shaping land use, investment, and long-term planning well beyond the payroll line.

LAND STEWARDSHIP: IDLE GROUND IS NO LONGER NEUTRAL

One of the most consequential and least discussed changes taking effect in 2026 gives county agricultural commissioners clearer authority to intervene when abandoned or unmanaged farmland becomes a pest, weed, or disease nuisance.

This authority does not require land to be farmed.

But it does mean that unmanaged ground can now trigger enforcement if it threatens neighboring operations or broader agricultural health.

As SGMA-driven fallowing accelerates across the Central Valley, this shift carries real implications. Large swaths of land are transitioning out of production, sometimes permanently. In many cases, landowners are responding to water constraints, economics, or regulatory uncertainty rather than choice.

Historically, idle land often faded into the background. In 2026, it does not.

County commissioners now sit at the intersection of environmental compliance, neighbor protection, and land stewardship expectations. Their authority is clearer, but so are the gray areas. What level of management is sufficient? When does neglect become a nuisance? How proactive must a landowner be when farming is no longer economically viable?

These are not abstract questions. They shape how fallowed land is maintained, what costs persist after production ends, and how conflicts between neighbors are resolved.

Doing nothing is no longer a neutral act. In some cases, it may now be a regulated one.

COMPOST, ORGANICS, AND THE STATE'S PREFERRED DIRECTION

Several changes taking effect in 2026 point clearly in the same direction. California wants more organic material diverted to farmland and fewer regulatory barriers standing in the way.

Expanded on-farm composting pathways, higher allowable application thresholds, and streamlined permitting processes are often discussed as soil health initiatives. They are that, but they are also something more. They align agriculture with the state's waste diversion, landfill reduction, and climate targets.

In effect, farmland is being positioned as part of California's environmental infrastructure.

This is not accidental. Organic waste management remains one of the state's most challenging compliance areas. Agriculture offers space, scale, and biological capacity that urban systems lack. Policy is responding accordingly.

For growers, this shift presents opportunity. Compost can improve soil structure, water-holding capacity, and long-term productivity. It can also introduce new operational considerations, regulatory responsibilities, and public scrutiny.

The signal is subtle but unmistakable. Farmland is increasingly viewed not only as production space, but also as processing space within California's environmental compliance system.

That shift carries benefits. It also carries expectations.

DIVERSIFICATION, WITH LOCAL CONTROL

New authority allowing counties to permit low-impact camping on private land reflects a broader regulatory trend. Diversification is encouraged, but only within carefully drawn local lines.

For some farms and ranches, this creates modest new income streams that complement traditional production. For others, it represents another example of opportunity shaped almost entirely by county interpretation and political climate.

Local control is the common thread. State law opens the door. Counties decide how wide.

In practice, this means that neighboring operations with similar land and similar challenges may face very different options depending on where they sit on the map. Permitting, enforcement, and community tolerance vary widely.

In 2026, where you farm matters as much as what you farm.

REGULATION IS NOT EXPANDING. IT IS REFINING

Updated pesticide rules, treated-seed restrictions, and tighter livestock medication standards do not dramatically expand regulatory authority. Instead, they narrow discretion.

These changes focus on definitions, documentation, and consistency. Ambiguity is reduced. Compliance expectations are clearer. Flexibility is thinner.

California's posture toward agriculture is no longer about launching new programs or pilot initiatives. It is about standardizing behavior, tightening definitions, and closing gaps that once allowed informal solutions.

Quietly.

Methodically.

Permanently.

WHAT THIS ADDS UP TO

No single law defines 2026 for California agriculture. Together, however, these changes send a clear and consistent signal.

Labor costs will continue to rise.

Idle land will face greater scrutiny.

Preferred practices will be nudged through incentives and regulatory relief.

Compliance will be quieter, but tighter.

Local enforcement will matter more than ever.

The cumulative effect is not chaos or collapse. It is compression. Margins tighten. Options narrow. Decisions carry more consequence.

In this issue of Farm Life, we take a closer look at two of the quietest, but most consequential, shifts now underway.

How counties are redefining land stewardship on fallowed ground.

How compost and organics policy is drawing agriculture deeper into the state's environmental compliance system.

These are not isolated stories. They are signals of where California agriculture is being steered.

In California agriculture, the biggest changes rarely arrive with a headline.

They show up later.

In the margins.

SGMA Litigation continued from page 2

requirements remain unresolved.

At the hearing, the Judge acknowledged awareness of the State's demands regarding those issues. An informal request for injunctive relief tied to those demands was raised. While the Judge did not act on that request at the hearing, it will be formally addressed in the February briefing.

At this stage, the Court has not endorsed the State's position and has not ruled on whether back fees may be imposed or whether specific reporting requirements will be enforced. Those questions remain unresolved.

What This Means for Farm Bureau Members

The most important takeaway from the hearing is what did not happen.

The Judge did not rule against the landowners. She did not accept the State's claim that the preliminary injunction no longer applies. She did not authorize fee collection. And she did not allow the case to be rushed to a merits decision.

Instead, the Court preserved the case's existing posture and required additional briefing on unresolved issues. That approach reflects judicial caution and confirms that the scope of State authority remains under review.

Members should continue to stay informed and retain any correspondence received from the State. However, nothing from this hearing changes any legal obligations immediately. The case remains active, and the Court has made clear that it intends to review the issues carefully before reaching conclusions.

Kings County Farm Bureau will continue to monitor the litigation closely and provide updates as filings are submitted and the March hearing approaches.

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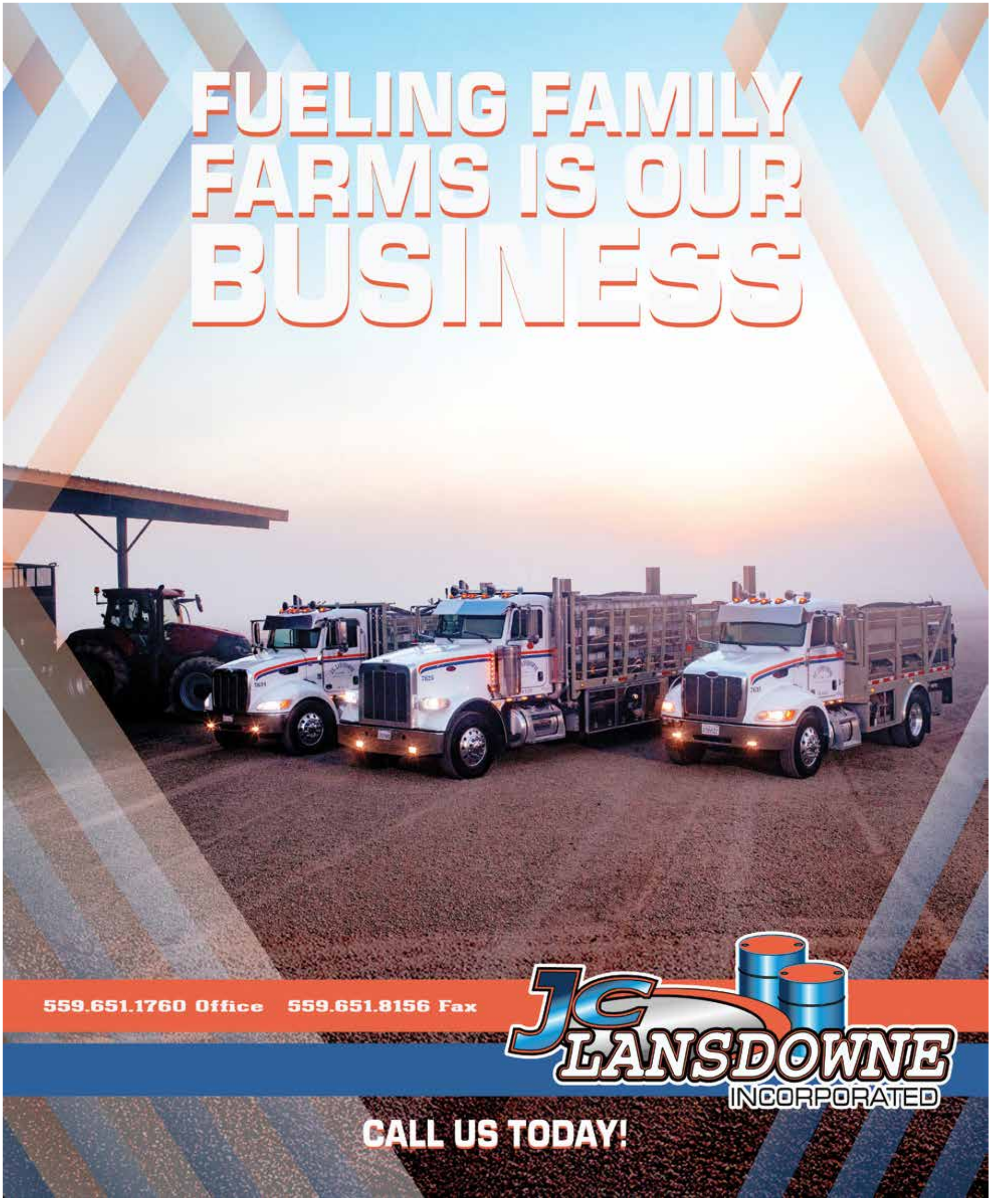
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